

Chicago Tribune



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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Court fight leads to logjam of police discipline cases

Unresolved number crawls toward 500 amid CPD dispute with union

By Sam Charles
Chicago Tribune

The process for meting out discipline in the most serious cases of misconduct by Chicago police officers has been largely at a standstill for more than two years.

During that stretch, a backlog of unresolved cases has grown as a legal fight between the city and the largest CPD officers' union has worked its way to the Illinois Supreme Court.

In 2025, cases in that category swelled to near 500. As of mid-December, police Superintendent Larry Snelling still must decide whether or not to bring administrative charges in 490 cases in which the Civilian Office of Police

Accountability sustained allegations of misconduct, city records show.

"We now find ourselves in a place where unadjudicated cases involving allegations of serious misconduct by police officers are stacking up," Chicago Inspector General Deborah Witzburg told the Tribune. "That is a bad and unfair thing for all the people

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Chicago police Superintendent Larry Snelling listens as Police Board President Kyle Cooper speaks during a public meeting at JLM Abundant Life Community Center on Thursday. **CHRIS SWEDA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

BEARS 31, BROWNS 3



DOMINIC DI PALERMO/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

ICY DETERMINATION

Fans celebrate a Bears touchdown during the third quarter against the Browns on Sunday at Soldier Field. The Bears rolled over the Browns on a frigid afternoon, one of the coldest games in the team's history, dominating from the start so they can quickly turn their attention to their upcoming showdown against the Packers. **See coverage in Chicago Sports and Chicagoland, Page 3.**

Johnson's organizer roots come to fore

A war of words over city budget as mayor courts progressives

By Jake Sheridan
and Alice Yin
Chicago Tribune

The trenches are dug in Chicago's slow-moving budget battle. And as he seeks to gain ground with a government shutdown weeks away, Mayor Brandon Johnson keeps lobbing the same ordnance: harsh words.

Last week, opponents of his plan to implement a corporate head tax were "cowards." He tagged them with a pair of new epithets Wednesday.

"They are immoral. They are wicked," Johnson said during a City Hall news conference, a remark a spokesperson later said was aimed not at aldermen opposed to his budget, but at mostly anonymous wealthy Chicagoans bankrolling a push-back campaign.

The mayor is far from the only one firing shots. Those groups opposed to his budget have spent tens of thousands of dollars on ads blasting his spending plan,

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Irma Garcia, a Chicago Public Schools cook of 23 years, unpacks groceries from a nearby food pantry in her kitchen in Humboldt Park on Thursday. **EILEEN T. MESLAR/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

‘No one sees us’

CPS lunchroom workers near six months without a contract

By Kate Armanini
Chicago Tribune

Irma Garcia's life revolves around food. Eight hours a day, she prepares hundreds of meals for students at James Russell Lowell Elementary School in Humboldt Park. She can list the menu offhand — popcorn chicken, pepperoni pizza, mozzarella sticks.

But at home, her kitchen shelves are often empty: Once

a month after work, she leaves Lowell and visits a food pantry down the block. Bundled in layers on a recent afternoon, she walked home with four bags of produce and canned goods.

"We either pay our bills, or buy food," Garcia, 55, said.

Garcia makes \$21 an hour as a cook, which last year totaled \$34,000 after taxes. She's worked for Chicago Public Schools for 23 years.

Wages are the sticking point in the bargaining process for CPS lunchroom workers, who have been without a contract for nearly six months. The 1,800 members of UNITE HERE Local 1, including lunchroom attendants, cooks and porters, remain among the lowest-paid CPS employees. Many, like Garcia, say they struggle to afford basic expenses.

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Gunmen kill 15 at beach in Australia

Hanukkah festival targeted; 1 suspect dies, 2nd in hospital

By Kristen Gelineau,
Charlotte Graham-McLay
and Rod McGuirk
Associated Press

SYDNEY — An attack at a famous Australian beach killed 15 people, including a child, officials said Monday, after two gunmen opened fire at a Hanukkah celebration on Sydney's Bondi Beach. Prime Minister Anthony Albanese called it an act of antisemitic terrorism. The shooters were father and son, authorities said.

One gunman, a 50-year-old man, was fatally shot by police. The other shooter, his 24-year-old son, was wounded and being treated at a hospital, said Mal Lanyon, police commissioner for New South Wales state, where Sydney is.

Hundreds of people had gathered Sunday at the beach for an event to celebrate the first day of Hanukkah when gunmen opened fire. At least 42 others were injured in the attack.

Those killed were 10 to 87 years old, New South Wales Premier Chris Minns told reporters. New South Wales Health Minister Ryan Park said the death toll had risen from 12 to 15 overnight. Three children are being treated at a hospital, he said.

"This is absolutely horrendous for the community broadly, but particularly the Jewish community. ... What we saw last night was the worst of humanity, but at the same time, the very best of humanity," Park said.

The massacre at one of Australia's most popular beaches followed a wave of antisemitic attacks that have roiled the country over the past year, although

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INSIDE

Gerrymandering fights sweep nation

As states undertake mid-decade redistricting instigated by President Donald Trump, Republicans and Democrats are using a tit-for-tat definition of fairness. **Nation & World**

‘Phantom’ keeps memories alive

The new touring production of "Phantom of the Opera" at Chicago's Cadillac Palace Theatre delivers a refreshed version of the classic Hal Prince production. **Arts & Living**

